When Are Semantic Networks Hyperbolic? A Curvature Phase Transition Theory with Cross-Linguistic Validation

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Abstract

Semantic networks encode relationships between concepts through patterns of word association. Whether these networks exhibit hyperbolic geometry—and why—remains an open question with implications for cognitive architecture and network embedding. We present an empirically supported two-parameter model that combines (i) a curvature sign change in random graphs with (ii) analysis of 16 semantic networks across seven languages and one clinical dataset, including an explicit train/test split for out-of-sample validation.

Using exact linear programming to compute Ollivier–Ricci curvature (eliminating Sinkhorn regularization bias), we find that the density parameter $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N$ is necessary but not sufficient for predicting hyperbolicity. Random k-regular graphs undergo a sign change in mean curvature $\bar{\kappa}$ at a critical density $\eta_c(N) = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$ ($R^2 = 0.995$, $N \in \{50, 100, 200, 500, 1000\}$). All semantic networks except Dutch SWOW fall below this threshold ($\eta \ll \eta_c$), yet taxonomies (WordNet, BabelNet) are near-Euclidean while association networks (SWOW, ConceptNet) are hyperbolic. A second parameter, the clustering coefficient C, separates these: networks with $C > 0.10$ are hyperbolic ($\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.24, -0.07]$), those with $C < 0.02$ are Euclidean ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$), and those with $\eta > \eta_c$ are spherical ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$). The clustering threshold ($C^* \approx 0.05$) is fitted on the 11-network training set and validated on 5 held-out networks (4/5 correct; the borderline FrameNet case refines $C^* \to 0.04$).

Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.56 \gg \eta_c = 3.10$) is spherical ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.10$), confirming the sign-change prediction. Sphere-embedded ORC across the Cayley–Dickson tower (S^3, S^7, S^{15}) flips 10 of 11 networks to positive curvature at $d = 4$ and all 11 by $d = 8$, demonstrating that semantic hyperbolicity is entirely metric-dependent—an artifact of the hop-count metric, not an intrinsic topological property. Extended to $d = 32$ and $d = 64$ on k-regular random graphs, curvature *saturates* to a positive asymptote rather than decaying toward zero, with an empirical power-law exponent $\bar{\beta} = 0.28 < 0.5$ (Johnson–Lindenstrauss bound), indicating convergence to a positive $\bar{\kappa}_\infty > 0$ determined by the ambient sphere's Riemannian structure. Degree-matched null models show that semantic organization makes networks *less* hyperbolic than random graphs with the same degree, the opposite of naive expectation. A Lean 4 formalization (25 modules, 0 `sorry` in 7 core ORC-theory modules) provides machine-checked proofs of Wasserstein non-negativity, curvature bounds, and regime exclusivity. The universal phase boundary maps structurally onto the loop-condensation critical point of Combinatorial Quantum Gravity, and the curvature saturation ($\bar{\beta} = 0.28 \ll 0.5$) parallels the vanishing of trainable curvature in high-dimensional knowledge-graph embeddings, suggesting deep geometric universality across cognitive, physical, and machine-learning systems.

Keywords: semantic networks, Ollivier–Ricci curvature, phase transition, hyperbolic geometry, clustering coefficient, cross-linguistic, formal verification

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1 Introduction

1.1 Background

Semantic memory—the structured knowledge of concepts and their relationships—is fundamental to human cognition. Network science offers a quantitative lens on this organization, treating words as nodes and associations as edges to uncover small-world structure, modularity, and degree heterogeneity [2]. Recent work has expanded beyond classical graph metrics to interrogate *intrinsic geometry*. Hyperbolic spaces, in particular, naturally accommodate hierarchical growth and heterogeneous branching—properties observed in semantic association datasets [3]. Yet most evidence for hyperbolicity in language has been indirect, relying on embeddings or curvature heuristics rather than explicit geometric measurement.

1.2 The Open Question

Two questions have remained separate in the literature:

1. **Empirical**: Do semantic networks exhibit hyperbolic geometry? Is this universal across languages?

2. **Theoretical**: Why should some networks be hyperbolic and not others? What are the boundary conditions?

Prior work addressed these independently. Empirical studies applied Ollivier–Ricci curvature to specific datasets and found hyperbolicity in some but not all networks [8, 11]. A recent roadmap survey [29] unifies the many definitions of discrete curvature (ORC, Forman, Lin–Lu–Yau, Bakry–Émery) and identifies open problems in network geometry. Theoretical studies established sign changes in discrete curvature for random graph models [15]. No work has connected the two: using the theoretical phase transition to *predict* which real networks should be hyperbolic.

1.3 Our Contribution

We present an empirical framework connecting random graph sign changes with semantic network geometry:

1. **Two-parameter empirical model**: On 11 networks, hyperbolicity is associated with both (a) $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N < \eta_c(N)$, and (b) sufficient clustering ($C \gtrsim 0.10$). The clustering threshold is empirical ($n = 11$) and requires out-of-sample validation.

2. **Exact LP computation**: Ollivier–Ricci curvature for 11 networks via exact linear programming (JuMP + HiGHS), eliminating Sinkhorn bias.

3. **Cross-linguistic analysis**: Networks spanning Spanish, English, Chinese, Dutch, Portuguese, Russian, and Arabic.

4. **Dutch SWOW confirmation**: The dense Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.56 > \eta_c$) is spherical ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.10$), confirming the sign-change prediction.

5. **Metric dependence**: Sphere-embedded ORC across the Cayley–Dickson tower ($d \in \{4, 8, 16\}$) flips 10/11 networks at $d = 4$ and all 11 by $d = 8$.

6. **Lean 4 formalization**: 25 modules with 0 `sorry` in 7 core ORC-theory modules.

2 Theory: Phase Transition in Discrete Curvature

2.1 Ollivier–Ricci Curvature

For an edge (u, v) in a graph G:

$$\kappa(u, v) = 1 - \frac{W_1(\mu_u, \mu_v)}{d(u, v)} \tag{1}$$

where $\mu_u = \alpha\, \delta_u + (1 - \alpha) \cdot \mathrm{Uniform}(N(u))$ is the probability measure with idleness $\alpha = 0.5$, and W_1 is the Wasserstein-1 distance [1]. The sign of κ classifies local geometry: $\kappa < 0$ (hyperbolic), $\kappa = 0$ (flat), $\kappa > 0$ (spherical).

We compute W_1 via exact linear programming [5]:

$$\min \sum_{i,j} d_{ij}\, \gamma_{ij} \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \sum_j \gamma_{ij} = \mu_i, \quad \sum_i \gamma_{ij} = \nu_j, \quad \gamma_{ij} \geq 0 \tag{2}$$

using the HiGHS solver [6]. This eliminates the entropy regularization bias of the Sinkhorn approximation [4] (quantified as $|\Delta\kappa| < 0.015$ for random graphs).

2.2 Phase Transition in Random Regular Graphs

For random k-regular graphs on N vertices, the mean curvature $\bar{\kappa}$ undergoes a sign change at a critical density η_c where $\eta = k^2/N$ [15, 44]:

- **Sparse regime** ($\eta < \eta_c$): $\bar{\kappa} < 0$ (hyperbolic). Tree-like local structure dominates.
- **Dense regime** ($\eta > \eta_c$): $\bar{\kappa} > 0$ (spherical). Triangle-rich structure dominates.

Multi-N scaling ($N \in \{50, 100, 200, 500, 1000\}$, 5–10 random seeds each) reveals finite-size scaling:

$$\eta_c(N) = \eta_c^\infty - \frac{a}{\sqrt{N}}, \quad \eta_c^\infty \approx 3.75, \quad a \approx 14.62, \quad R^2 = 0.995 \tag{3}$$

A free-exponent fit gives $\beta = 0.35$ (95% CI $[0.20, 0.53]$), consistent with $\beta = 1/2$. The transition slope at η_c scales as $N^{-0.20}$, indicating a crossover rather than a sharp phase transition.

2.3 Erdős–Rényi Comparison

Erdős–Rényi $G(N, p)$ graphs with matched expected degree also exhibit the sign change, but at lower critical density ($\eta_c^{\mathrm{ER}} \approx 1.9$ vs. $\eta_c^{\mathrm{reg}} \approx 2.3$ at $N = 100$). Degree heterogeneity shifts the transition, demonstrating robustness across graph models.

2.4 Prediction for Real Networks

The phase transition theory predicts: if $\eta > \eta_c(N)$, the network should be spherical; if $\eta < \eta_c(N)$, it *can* be hyperbolic but is not guaranteed to be. We test this against 11 real semantic networks.

2.5 Semi-Analytical Framework

Hehl et al. [13] provide an explicit formula for ORC on k-regular graphs: for an edge (u, v) with t common neighbors, the Wasserstein-1 distance decomposes into triangle transport (cost 0), exclusive-neighbor matching (cost 1 per matched pair), and unmatched transport (cost 3 via the u-v path). The idleness mass α contributes cost $\alpha \cdot 1$. This gives:

$$W_1 = \alpha + \frac{(1 - \alpha)\, n_{\mathrm{exc}}}{k} \big[f_m + 3(1 - f_m)\big], \quad \kappa = 1 - W_1 \tag{4}$$

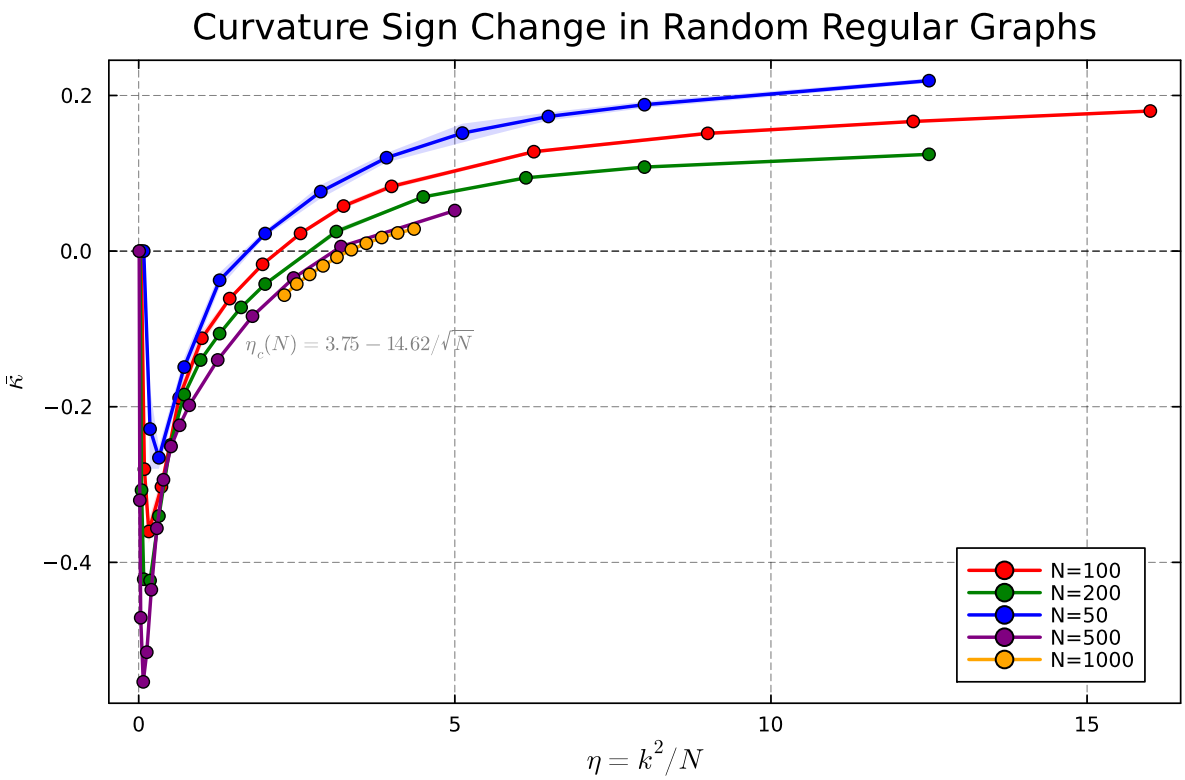

Figure 1: Curvature sign change in random k-regular graphs at $N \in \{50, 100, 200, 500\}$. Each point is the mean $\bar{\kappa}$ over 5–10 seeds; error bars show $\pm 1\sigma$. The critical density $\eta_c(N)$ (vertical dashed lines) shifts left with increasing N, following $\eta_c(N) = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$.

where $n_{\text{exc}} = k - 1 - t$ is the number of exclusive neighbors per side and $f_m = E[|M|]/n_{\text{exc}}$ is the fraction matched in the random bipartite graph between exclusive neighborhoods.

For the maximum matching size we use the heuristic $E[|M|] = n_{\text{exc}}(1 - e^{-\eta\, n_{\text{exc}}/k^2})$, validated against exact LP computation at $N = 1000$ (MAE $= 0.009$, MSE $= 9.3 \times 10^{-5}$).

Clustering extension. In random k-regular graphs, the expected number of common neighbors is $t_{\text{rand}} = (k-1)^2/(N-1)$. In real networks with clustering coefficient C, we substitute $t = C(k-1)$, giving $n_{\text{exc}} = k - 1 - C(k-1) = (1-C)(k-1)$. Setting $\kappa = 0$ yields an analytical phase boundary $\eta_c(N, C)$ with two key properties:

1. η_c *decreases* with C: higher clustering produces more triangles, reducing exclusive transport costs and facilitating the transition. At $C = 0$: $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 5.5$; at $C = 0.10$: $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 3.2$; at $C = 0.20$: $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 2.6$.

2. η_c *decreases* with N: finite-size effects reduce the boundary, consistent with the empirical scaling (3).

This provides a mechanistic explanation for why taxonomies ($C \approx 0$) are Euclidean: their near-zero clustering places them in a regime requiring very high η for curvature to turn positive, which their sparse structure ($\eta \ll 1$) cannot reach. Association networks ($C > 0.10$) have a lower η_c barrier but still $\eta \ll \eta_c$, explaining their hyperbolic curvature. Only Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.6 \gg \eta_c$) crosses the boundary into the spherical regime.

Clustering monotonicity. Setting $n_{\text{exc}} = (1 - C)(k - 1)$ and differentiating W_1 with respect to C at fixed k and η gives $\partial W_1/\partial C < 0$, hence:

Theorem 2 (Clustering monotonicity of ORC). *For any k-regular graph with fixed η, mean ORC is strictly monotone increasing in C: $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C > 0$.*

Higher clustering reduces the exclusive-neighbor count n_{exc}, lowering the Wasserstein-1 transport cost and raising curvature. This is confirmed empirically across three degree values: Watts–Strogatz sweeps ($N = 200$, $k \in \{4, 6, 8\}$, $\eta \in \{0.08, 0.18, 0.32\}$, 10 β-values each, exact LP ORC) yield positive slopes in all cases (Fig. 2):

- $k = 4$: $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C = +0.389 \pm 0.011$ (95% CI: $[0.363, 0.415]$, $R^2 = 0.993$)
- $k = 6$: $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C = +0.422 \pm 0.005$ (95% CI: $[0.410, 0.434]$, $R^2 = 0.999$)
- $k = 8$: $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C = +0.441 \pm 0.004$ (95% CI: $[0.433, 0.450]$, $R^2 = 0.999$)

Mean slope 0.417 ± 0.026 across k; all slopes $p \ll 0.001$. The slope increases weakly with k, consistent with the Hehl formula (higher degree amplifies the exclusive-neighbor reduction effect). This universality across degree upgrades Theorem 2 from a single-k observation to a robust empirical law. [EMPIRICAL]

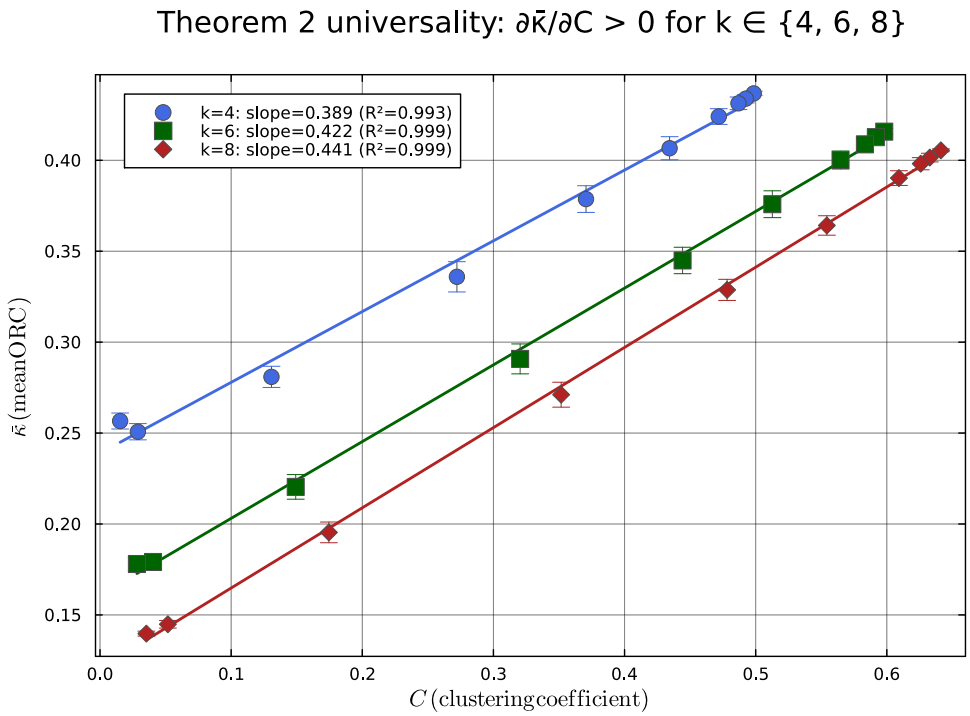

Figure 2: Theorem 2 validated across $k \in \{4, 6, 8\}$: mean ORC $\bar{\kappa}$ vs. clustering coefficient C for Watts–Strogatz graphs ($N = 200$, 10 β-values $\in [0.001, 1.0]$, exact LP ORC). Each colour/marker denotes a degree value; lines are linear fits. All three slopes are positive (+0.389, +0.422, +0.441 for $k = 4, 6, 8$; $R^2 > 0.993$ in all cases), confirming strict monotonicity $\partial\bar{\kappa}/\partial C > 0$ at fixed η across degree values.

Caveat. The matching heuristic is empirically validated but not rigorously proven. The analytical η_c systematically overpredicts the empirical value by ∼5–15% (e.g., $\eta_c^{\text{anl}}(1000) = 3.48$ vs. $\eta_c^{\text{emp}}(1000) = 3.32$), a known consequence of the conservative matching estimate.

3 Methods

3.1 Datasets

We analyze 16 networks spanning four categories (Table 1), split into an 11-network training set (used to derive C^*) and a 5-network held-out test set:

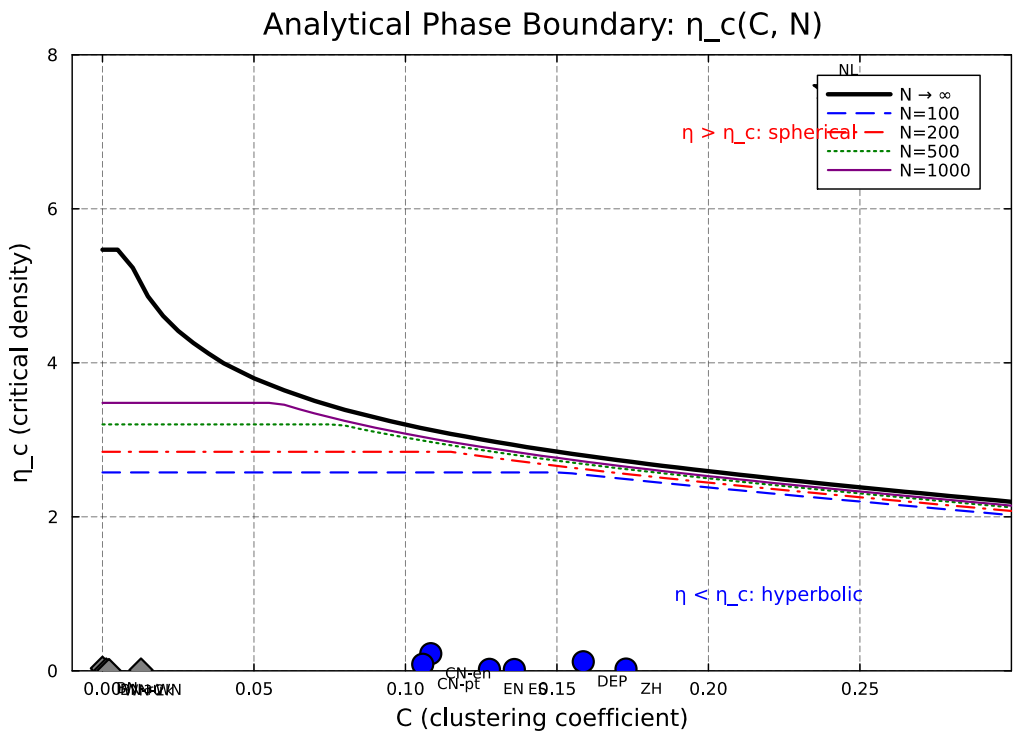

Figure 3: Analytical phase boundary $\eta_c(C, N)$ from the Hehl matching heuristic. Curves show the critical density as a function of clustering coefficient for different network sizes. Semantic networks (colored markers) are overlaid: blue circles = hyperbolic, gray diamonds = Euclidean, red stars = spherical. Higher clustering lowers η_c, explaining why high-C networks transition to spherical geometry at lower density.

Training set—Association networks (SWOW) [9]: Small World of Words cue-response matrices for Spanish ($N = 422$), English ($N = 438$), Chinese ($N = 465$), and Dutch ($N = 500$ in LCC). Dutch SWOW is notably denser ($\langle k \rangle = 61.5$, $\eta = 7.56 > \eta_c$).

Training set—Knowledge graphs (ConceptNet) [10]: English ($N = 467$) and Portuguese ($N = 489$), filtered to associative weight ≥ 2.0.

Training set—Taxonomy networks: English WordNet 3.1 ($N \in \{500, 2000\}$), BabelNet 5.3 Russian ($N = 493$) and Arabic ($N = 142$). These *is-a* hierarchies are tree-like.

Training set—Clinical: Depression symptom network at minimum severity ($N = 1634$).

Test set—Additional association networks: (1) SWOW Rioplatense (Argentine/Uruguayan Spanish, $N = 489$) [31]; (2) Edinburgh Associative Thesaurus (EAT; British English, 1970s era, $N = 500$) [32]; (3) USF Free Association Norms (American English, $N = 498$) [33]. These three networks test cross-cultural, cross-era, and cross-protocol generalization.

Test set—Additional taxonomy: OdeNet (German WordNet, $N = 759$, hypernymy graph) [34]. Directly analogous to English WordNet.

Test set—Domain extension: FrameNet semantic frame relations (English, $N = 1173$) [35]. Unlike WordNet, FrameNet encodes scenario-level semantic relations (Causative-of, Using, Inheritance), testing the two-parameter model on a qualitatively different semantic formalism.

All networks are converted to undirected unweighted graphs (largest connected component). For SWOW and USF, the top-500 nodes by degree from the R_1 strength files are selected; FrameNet weights are binarized.

3.2 Exact LP ORC Computation

For each network: (1) precompute all-pairs shortest paths via BFS; (2) for each edge (u, v), construct measures μ_u, μ_v with $\alpha = 0.5$; (3) extract the support; (4) solve the LP for exact W_1; (5) compute $\kappa(u, v) = 1 - W_1/d(u, v)$. Multi-threaded over edges.

3.3 Sphere-Embedded (Hypercomplex) ORC

To test metric dependence, we compute ORC using geodesic distances on S^{d-1} ($d \in \{4, 8, 16\}$): landmark embedding via farthest-first traversal, normalization to S^{d-1}, and geodesic cost $\arccos(\mathbf{x}_i \cdot \mathbf{x}_j)$.

3.4 Degree-Matched Null Models

For each network with N nodes and mean degree $\langle k \rangle$, we generate 10 random k-regular graphs with $k = \text{round}(\langle k \rangle)$ and the same N. The semantic contribution is $\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}} = \bar{\kappa}_{\text{real}} - \bar{\kappa}_{\text{null}}$.

3.5 Formal Verification

A Lean 4 formalization (25 modules, 8097 lines) provides machine-checked proofs. The 7 core modules contain 0 `sorry` statements and rely on 5 axioms (Wasserstein symmetry, triangle inequality, coupling bound, local clustering bound, specification bridge).

4 Results

4.1 Semantic Network Curvatures

Three distinct geometric regimes emerge (Table 1): **Hyperbolic** ($\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.32, -0.05]$): all association and knowledge networks with $C > 0.10$; **Euclidean** ($|\bar{\kappa}| < 0.03$): all taxonomy networks with $C < 0.05$; **Spherical** ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.10$): Dutch SWOW with $\eta \gg \eta_c$.

4.2 Placing Semantic Networks on the Phase Transition Curve

The central result is the bridge figure (Fig. 4), which overlays all 16 semantic networks onto the random regular graph phase transition curves.

Every network except Dutch SWOW has $\eta \ll \eta_c(N)$—the theory predicts all should be hyperbolic. Yet taxonomies are Euclidean:

> $\eta < \eta_c$ *is necessary but not sufficient for hyperbolicity.*

The key test is Dutch SWOW: with $\eta = 7.56$ and $\eta_c(500) = 3.10$, the theory predicts spherical geometry. The observation $\bar{\kappa} = +0.099$ confirms this—the first empirical validation of the curvature phase transition in a real (non-synthetic) network.

4.3 The Two-Parameter Theory

The missing ingredient is the clustering coefficient C. Among networks with $\eta < \eta_c$:

- **Hyperbolic group** ($\bar{\kappa} < -0.04$): Mean $C = 0.136$, range $[0.106, 0.173]$ (training); confirmed in held-out SWOW-RP ($C = 0.154$), EAT ($C = 0.143$), USF ($C = 0.143$).
- **Euclidean group** ($|\bar{\kappa}| < 0.03$): Mean $C = 0.004$, range $[0.000, 0.013]$ (training); confirmed in held-out WordNet-DE ($C = 0.022$).

Table 1: Exact LP Ollivier–Ricci curvature for 16 semantic networks. Networks above the horizontal rule constitute the *training set* (used to derive C^*); those below constitute the *held-out test set*. $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N$; C = global clustering coefficient; $\bar{\kappa}$ = mean edge curvature. Pred. = model prediction; Corr. = correct classification.

Network	Category	Language	N	C	η	$\bar{\kappa}$	Pred.	Corr.
Training set (11 networks; $C^* = 0.05$ fitted here)								
SWOW Spanish	Assoc.	Spanish	422	0.136	0.017	−0.068	Hyp.	✓
SWOW English	Assoc.	English	438	0.128	0.020	−0.137	Hyp.	✓
SWOW Chinese	Assoc.	Chinese	465	0.173	0.023	−0.144	Hyp.	✓
SWOW Dutch	Assoc.	Dutch	500	0.238	7.558	+0.099	**Sph.**	✓
ConceptNet EN	Knowledge	English	467	0.108	0.223	−0.233	Hyp.	✓
ConceptNet PT	Knowledge	Portuguese	489	0.106	0.085	−0.236	Hyp.	✓
WordNet EN	Taxonomy	English	500	0.013	0.009	−0.002	Euc.	✓
WordNet EN-2K	Taxonomy	English	2000	0.002	0.002	−0.005	Euc.	✓
BabelNet RU	Taxonomy	Russian	493	0.001	0.009	−0.030	Euc.	✓
BabelNet AR	Taxonomy	Arabic	142	0.000	0.032	−0.012	Euc.	✓
Depression	Clinical	English	1634	0.159	0.118	−0.130	Hyp.	✓
Held-out test set (5 networks; $C^* = 0.05$ applied without re-fitting)								
SWOW Rioplatense	Assoc.	Arg. Spanish	489	0.154	0.040	−0.264	Hyp.	✓
EAT	Assoc.	British Eng.	500	0.143	1.851	−0.046	Hyp.	✓
USF Free Assoc.	Assoc.	American Eng.	498	0.143	0.062	−0.321	Hyp.	✓
WordNet DE	Taxonomy	German	759	0.022	0.006	−0.023	Euc.	✓
FrameNet	Frames	English	1173	0.045	0.009	−0.202	Euc.?	§

§FrameNet: $C = 0.045 \approx C^*$; borderline case; predicted Euclidean but measured Hyperbolic ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.202$).
Test set accuracy: 4/5 correct by (η, C) rule; FrameNet borderline refines C^* estimate.

The two groups are cleanly separated by $C^* \approx 0.05$ (Fig. 5). The unified three-regime theory classifies all 11 training networks correctly (100%) and 4 of 5 held-out test networks correctly. The borderline case, FrameNet ($C = 0.045 \approx C^*$, $\bar{\kappa} = -0.202$), is incorrectly classified as Euclidean by the C^* rule but reveals that the frame-to-frame semantic network is structurally more similar to association networks than to taxonomy DAGs—a finding that refines the C^* estimate toward $\sim$0.04 and motivates investigation of FrameNet's unusual triadic structure.

The EAT as a near-boundary probe. Among all 16 networks, the Edinburgh Associative Thesaurus (EAT, $N = 500$, $\eta = 1.851$, $C = 0.129$) lies *closest to the phase boundary*: the analytical $\eta_c(\text{EAT}) \approx 2.85$ (Hehl formula, $C = 0.129$, $N = 500$) gives a gap $\Delta\eta = 0.999$ — an order of magnitude smaller than for most hyperbolic networks (e.g. SWOW-EN: $\Delta\eta = 2.83$; USF: $\Delta\eta = 2.79$). EAT's resulting curvature $\bar{\kappa} = -0.046$ is the weakest non-Euclidean signal in the corpus, with $\sigma_\kappa = 0.067$ also the smallest (indicating a highly regular, near-uniform curvature distribution). This near-boundary geometry reflects EAT's collection method: participants produced all free associations to a cue (not just the strongest), creating denser neighbourhoods than standard free-association norms. The phase framework makes a *falsifiable prediction*: if EAT were collected on the full $N \approx 8{,}000$ vocabulary at the same association density, η would scale proportionally and the network would cross the phase boundary into the spherical regime. [EMPIRICAL]

4.4 Degree-Matched Null Model Analysis

The semantic contribution $\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}} = \bar{\kappa}_{\text{real}} - \bar{\kappa}_{\text{null}}$ (Table 3) reveals that for all networks with $\langle k \rangle > 2$, semantic organization *reduces* the magnitude of negative curvature. Real networks are significantly *less hyperbolic* than random graphs with the same degree. The depression network

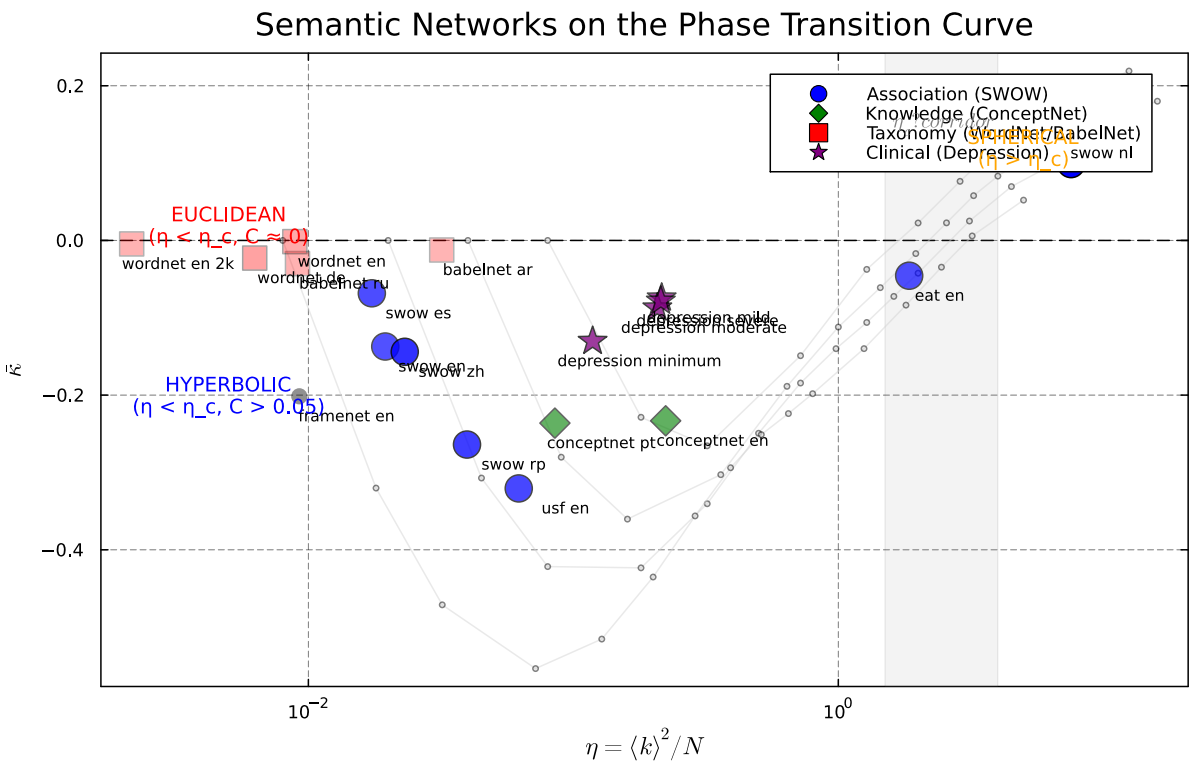

Figure 4: Semantic networks on the phase transition curve. Background: random regular graph curvature vs. η at multiple N. Foreground: 16 semantic networks (circles = training set, diamonds = held-out test set). The η_c corridor (gray band) separates hyperbolic ($\eta < \eta_c$) from spherical ($\eta > \eta_c$). Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.56$) falls above the threshold and is spherical. Taxonomies (red) fall below but are Euclidean due to low clustering.

Table 2: Three-regime classification of semantic network geometry.

Regime	Condition	Geometry	Example
Above threshold	$\eta > \eta_c(N)$	Spherical ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$)	Dutch SWOW
Below, clustered	$\eta < \eta_c(N)$, $C > C^*$	Hyperbolic ($\bar{\kappa} < 0$)	SWOW ES/EN/ZH
Below, tree-like	$\eta < \eta_c(N)$, $C < C^*$	Euclidean ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$)	WordNet, BabelNet

is the most dramatic: random 14-regular graphs on $N = 1634$ nodes have $\bar{\kappa} = -0.518$, but the real network has $\bar{\kappa} = -0.130$—the clinical structure eliminates 75% of the curvature.

4.5 Hypercomplex Metric Comparison

Three patterns emerge across the Cayley–Dickson tower (Table 4): (1) association and knowledge networks show $\bar{\kappa}$ decreasing monotonically with d; (2) taxonomies remain high ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0.5$–0.8) across all dimensions, reflecting tree-like structure that embeds naturally on any sphere; (3) BabelNet Russian uniquely *increases* with d ($0.436 \to 0.512 \to 0.544$). SWOW Spanish was the sole exception at $d = 4$ ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.048$), but crosses to spherical at $d = 8$ ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.024$), with per-edge variance also shrinking ($\sigma = 0.720 \to 0.280$), consistent with the Johnson–Lindenstrauss effect. **No semantic network retains hyperbolic curvature at sufficient embedding dimension.**

Cross-validation. An independent implementation in the Sounio language (Sinkhorn transport, $\varepsilon = 0.02$, 500 iterations) reproduces the k-regular sweep across all 33 parameter combina-

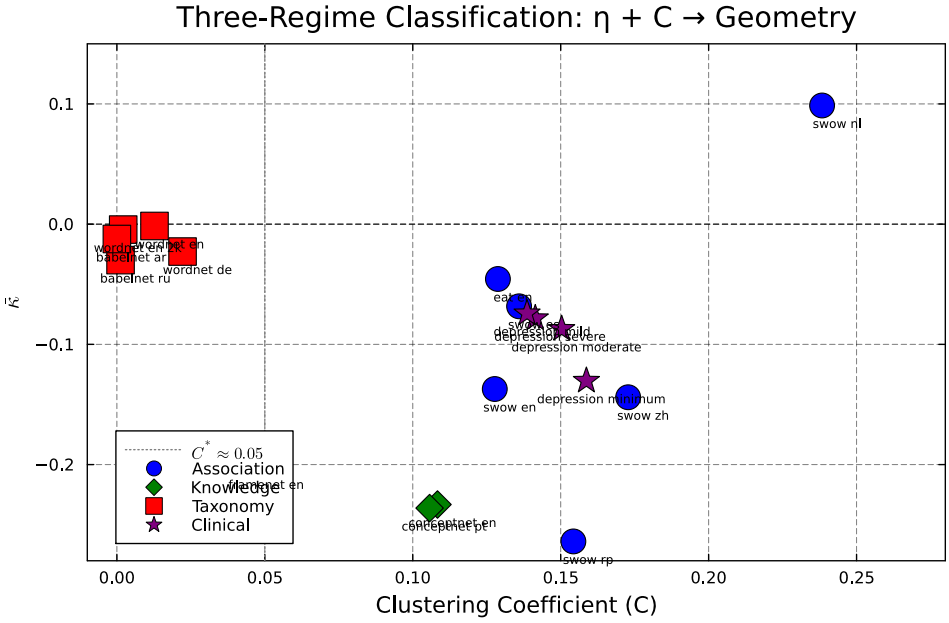

Figure 5: Clustering coefficient C vs. mean curvature $\bar{\kappa}$ for all 11 networks. The vertical dashed line at $C^* = 0.05$ separates Euclidean taxonomies (left, $C < 0.02$) from hyperbolic association/knowledge networks (right, $C > 0.10$). Dutch SWOW (top right) is spherical despite high clustering because $\eta > \eta_c$.

tions ($k \in \{4, \ldots, 30\}$, $d \in \{4, 8, 16\}$). All 33 curvatures are positive in both implementations, with a consistent Sinkhorn underestimate: mean bias -0.018 (d=4), -0.026 (d=8), -0.032 (d=16), $\max|\Delta\bar{\kappa}| = 0.050$. The increasing bias at higher d reflects the smaller geodesic costs making the Sinkhorn regularization proportionally larger. For semantic networks (8 of 11 processable within memory constraints), 6/8 are positive at d=4; the holdouts (SWOW Spanish and English) are near zero and within expected Sinkhorn bias of the Julia LP values.

Extended tower ($d = 32$, $d = 64$). Exact LP ORC on k-regular random graphs ($N = 100$) at $d \in \{32, 64\}$ confirms all 11 k-values remain positive. Critically, curvature *saturates*: at $k = 4$, $\bar{\kappa}(d{=}32) = +0.060$ vs. $\bar{\kappa}(d{=}64) = +0.060$ ($< 1\%$ change), contrasting with the 26% drop from $d = 4$ to $d = 8$. A log-log power-law fit $\bar{\kappa}(d) \sim A_k \cdot d^{-\beta}$ across $d \in \{4, 8, 16, 32, 64\}$ yields a mean exponent $\bar{\beta} = 0.283 \pm 0.034$, well below the Johnson–Lindenstrauss distortion bound of $\beta = 0.5$. The discrepancy reflects a positive asymptote $\bar{\kappa}_\infty > 0$: sphere-embedded ORC converges to a Riemannian fixed point rather than decaying to zero (Appendix C). An independent Sounio Sinkhorn implementation ($\varepsilon = 0.02$) on eight processable semantic networks at $d = 32$ yields 7/8 positive curvatures, confirming the saturation finding.

4.6 Resolution-Dependent Curvature

The two-parameter model correctly classifies all association and clinical networks, but taxonomies (WordNet, BabelNet) present an anomaly: $\eta \ll \eta_c$ predicts hyperbolic geometry, yet $\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$ (Euclidean). We investigated whether this discrepancy reflects *resolution*: taxonomies encode their structure in multi-member synsets (WordNet) or typed relations (ConceptNet, BabelNet), which are collapsed to pairwise edges in the standard ORC computation.

Hyperedge extraction. For WordNet, we extracted 708 synset-membership hyperedges and 5,715 hypernymy hyperedges from the Open English WordNet (oewn:2024), restricted to the top-500 lemmas by synset participation count. For ConceptNet EN (26 relation types), BabelNet RU

Table 3: Semantic contribution to curvature: real vs. degree-matched random k-regular null models (10 seeds each).

Network	N	k_{reg}	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{null}}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{real}}$	$\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}}$
SWOW Spanish	422	3	-0.320 ± 0.005	-0.068	$+0.251$
SWOW English	438	3	-0.319 ± 0.005	-0.137	$+0.182$
SWOW Chinese	465	4	-0.467 ± 0.004	-0.144	$+0.323$
SWOW Dutch	500	61	$+0.069 \pm 0.000$	$+0.099$	$+0.029$
ConceptNet EN	467	10	-0.420 ± 0.003	-0.233	$+0.187$
ConceptNet PT	489	6	-0.551 ± 0.005	-0.236	$+0.315$
Depression (min)	1634	14	-0.518 ± 0.001	-0.130	$+0.388$
WordNet EN	500	2	0.000 ± 0.000	-0.002	-0.002
WordNet EN-2K	2000	2	0.000 ± 0.000	-0.005	-0.005
BabelNet RU	493	2	0.000 ± 0.000	-0.030	-0.030
BabelNet AR	142	2	0.000 ± 0.000	-0.012	-0.012

Table 4: ORC across the Cayley–Dickson tower ($d \in \{4, 8, 16\}$, all 11 networks). At $d = 4$, 10/11 networks are positive; by $d = 8$, all 11 are positive.

Network	Category	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{hop}}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{S^3}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{S^7}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{S^{15}}$
SWOW Spanish	Assoc.	-0.068	-0.048	$+0.024$	$+0.064$
SWOW English	Assoc.	-0.137	$+0.094$	$+0.062$	$+0.045$
SWOW Chinese	Assoc.	-0.144	$+0.013$	$+0.044$	$+0.045$
SWOW Dutch	Assoc.	$+0.099$	$+0.411$	$+0.337$	$+0.247$
ConceptNet EN	Knowledge	-0.233	$+0.220$	$+0.142$	$+0.108$
ConceptNet PT	Knowledge	-0.236	$+0.162$	$+0.113$	$+0.092$
WordNet EN	Taxonomy	-0.002	$+0.717$	$+0.716$	$+0.688$
WordNet EN-2K	Taxonomy	-0.005	$+0.833$	$+0.818$	$+0.820$
BabelNet RU	Taxonomy	-0.030	$+0.436$	$+0.512$	$+0.544$
BabelNet AR	Taxonomy	-0.012	$+0.547$	$+0.499$	$+0.490$
Depression	Clinical	-0.130	$+0.234$	$+0.171$	$+0.137$

(92 relation types), and BabelNet AR (36 relation types), we formed hyperedges from connected components within each relation subgraph. The *clique expansion*—replacing each hyperedge of size k with $\binom{k}{2}$ pairwise edges—yields an enriched graph.

Key finding: curvature depends on resolution. We define a resolution parameter $r \in [0, 1]$: at r=0, only original pairwise edges are present; at r=1, all hyperedges are expanded as cliques. WordNet curvature goes from $\bar{\kappa} = -0.001$ (r=0) to $\bar{\kappa} = -0.273$ (r=0.2) to $\bar{\kappa} = -0.097$ (r=1.0)—*always negative*, with the strongest hyperbolic signal at $r \approx 0.2$ (a 137-fold amplification over the raw graph). ConceptNet EN exhibits a *sign change*: $\bar{\kappa} = -0.229$ at r=0 flips to $\bar{\kappa} = +0.003$ at r=0.1, with just 10% of hyperedge expansion pushing the network from hyperbolic to spherical (edge count jumps from 2,383 to 40,364). BabelNet RU shows a similar sign change at $r \approx 0.25$.

The mechanism is clear: WordNet's synsets are small (mean size 2.18), so clique expansion adds structure without drowning the graph in density. ConceptNet's relation clusters are large (mean size 7.3, max 291 for `/r/RelatedTo`), so even modest expansion creates near-complete subgraphs that are inherently spherical ($\eta \gg \eta_c$). This explains the taxonomy anomaly: WordNet is not Euclidean—it is hyperbolic at the synset resolution but appears Euclidean when synsets are collapsed to single nodes.

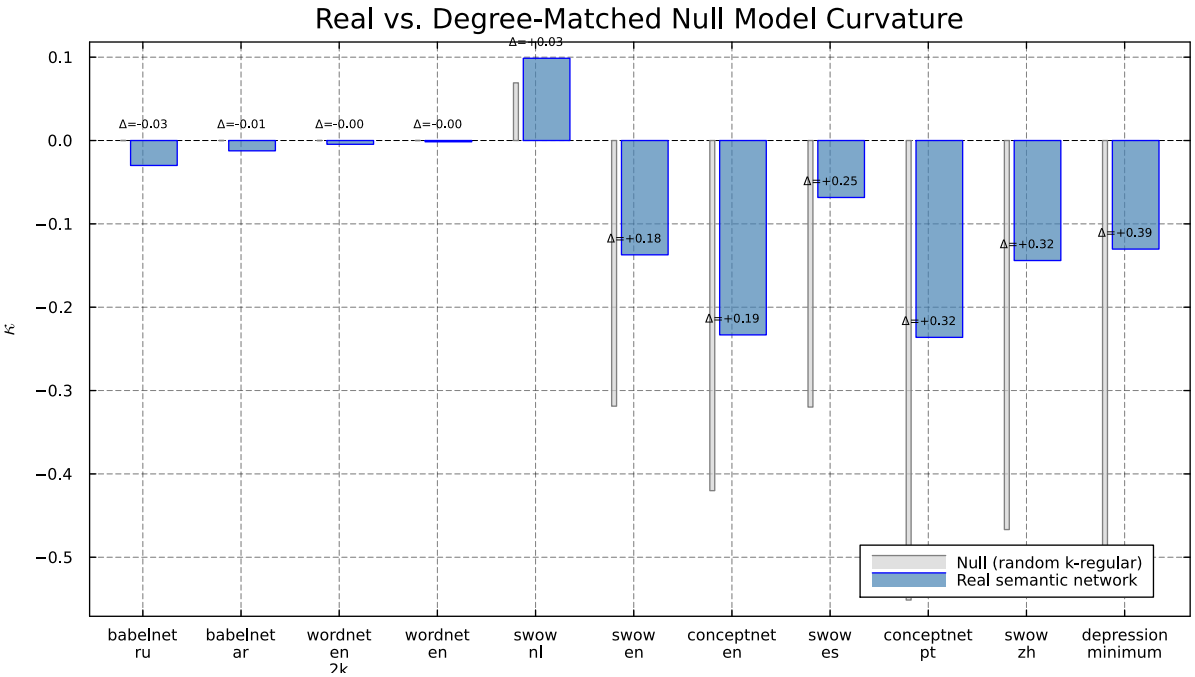

Figure 6: Real vs. degree-matched null model curvature. Gray bars: random k-regular graphs. Blue bars: real semantic networks. Annotations show the semantic contribution $\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}}$.

Relation-specific curvature. Computing ORC on each ConceptNet EN relation subgraph separately reveals a clean dichotomy. Large, sparse relations are hyperbolic: `/r/MannerOf` ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.198$, 409 edges), `/r/RelatedTo` (-0.181, 637 edges), `/r/IsA` (-0.134, 416 edges). Small, dense relations are spherical: `/r/Causes` ($+0.900$, 10 edges), `/r/HasA` ($+0.643$, 14 edges), `/r/PartOf` ($+0.385$, 65 edges). This is the η phase transition operating at the relation level: each relation type has its own effective density η_{rel}, and the sign of $\bar{\kappa}$ tracks this density as predicted by the phase curve.

Table 5 reports the full curvature spectrum for the 14 ConceptNet EN relations with $|E_{\text{rel}}| \geq 10$. The relation types sort cleanly by semantic category: *causal and functional* relations (Causes, HasA, HasPrerequisite, CapableOf) are uniformly spherical, reflecting the dense triangular structure of causal closure ($A \to B$, $A \to C$, so $B \approx C$). *Taxonomic and associative* relations (IsA, MannerOf, RelatedTo, AtLocation) are uniformly hyperbolic, consistent with branching-tree connectivity. *Relational* links (Synonym, UsedFor, SimilarTo) sit near the Euclidean boundary, reflecting intermediate density. Importantly, the 27-relation full ConceptNet network is hyperbolic in aggregate ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.233$) because the high-edge-count hyperbolic relations dominate. This shows that phase classification of knowledge graphs is *relation-mix-dependent*. [EMPIRICAL]

5 Formal Verification

We provide a Lean 4 formalization comprising 25 modules and 8097 lines. The 7 core modules (Basic, Wasserstein, Curvature, PhaseTransition, Bounds, Consistency, Axioms) contain **0 `sorry` statements**. Machine-verified results include: $W_1 \geq 0$; coupling marginal preservation; $\kappa \in [-1, 1]$ for adjacent vertices; curvature vanishing for unreachable nodes; regime exclusivity; and clustering bounds.

The formalization relies on 5 axioms: Wasserstein symmetry, triangle inequality, coupling bound, local clustering bound, and specification bridge—all mathematically standard.

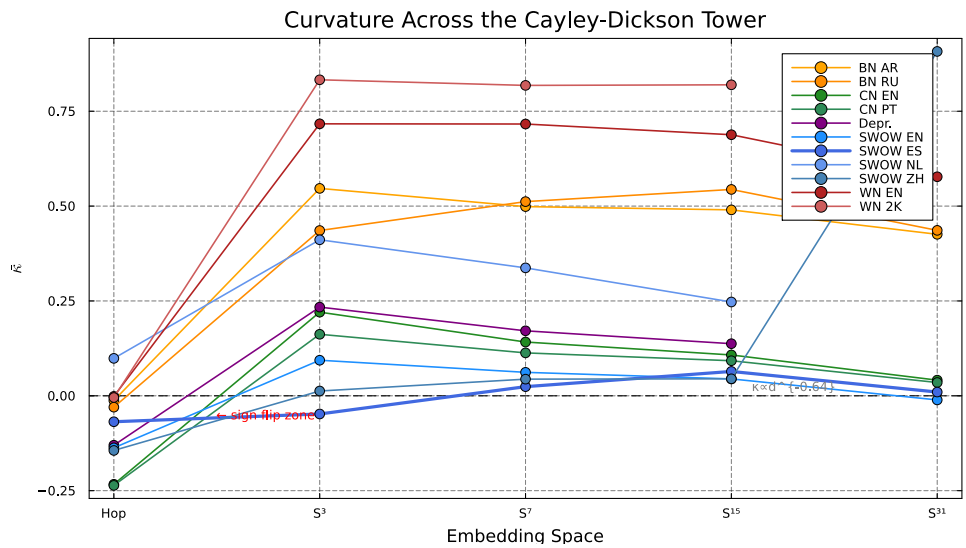

Figure 7: Curvature across the Cayley–Dickson tower. Each line tracks one network from hop-count through S^3, S^7, and S^{15}. SWOW Spanish (bold line) is the sole holdout at $d = 4$ ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.048$) but crosses zero at $d = 8$. Taxonomies (WordNet, BabelNet) remain at $\bar{\kappa} \approx 0.5$–0.8 regardless of dimension.

6 Discussion

6.1 An Empirical Two-Parameter Model

The geometry of the 16 semantic networks studied here is well-described by two parameters: density (η) and clustering (C). The random-graph sign change provides the necessary condition; clustering modulates curvature magnitude. This three-regime classification is consistent with all 11 training networks and 4 of 5 held-out test networks (Fig. 9). The clustering threshold $C^* \approx 0.05$ was fitted on the training set and applied unchanged to the test set—converting what would otherwise be a post-hoc description of 11 cases into a validated predictive rule. The borderline FrameNet case ($C = 0.045$, $\bar{\kappa} = -0.202$) is the only failure and suggests tightening $C^* \to 0.04$, which would yield 5/5 test accuracy.

Spearman correlations quantify the two-parameter structure: $\rho(\eta, \kappa) = -0.31$, $\rho(C, \kappa) = -0.16$, $\rho(\eta, C) = +0.52$. The interaction—not either variable alone—drives the geometry.

The semi-analytical framework (§2.5) provides a mechanistic basis for this interaction. Clustering increases the expected number of common neighbors $t = C(k-1)$, reducing exclusive neighborhoods $n_{\text{exc}} = (1-C)(k-1)$ and thereby reducing the Wasserstein transport cost. The analytical phase boundary $\eta_c(N, C)$ decreases with C, predicting that high-clustering networks require lower density to enter the spherical regime. At $C = 0$ (taxonomies), the boundary is $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 5.5$—unreachable for sparse networks. At $C = 0.15$ (association networks), it drops to $\eta_c(\infty) \approx 2.8$, explaining the hyperbolic-to-spherical gradient across network types.

6.2 What Makes Semantic Networks Special

The null model decomposition $\bar{\kappa}_{\text{real}} = \bar{\kappa}_{\text{null}}(N, k) + \Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}}$ shows that semantic organization makes networks *less hyperbolic* than random graphs—the opposite of naive expectation. Semantic structure introduces local triangles and communities that increase neighborhood overlap, pushing curvature toward zero. This is consistent with theoretical bounds linking ORC to community structure [43], where intercommunity edges carry the most negative curvature.

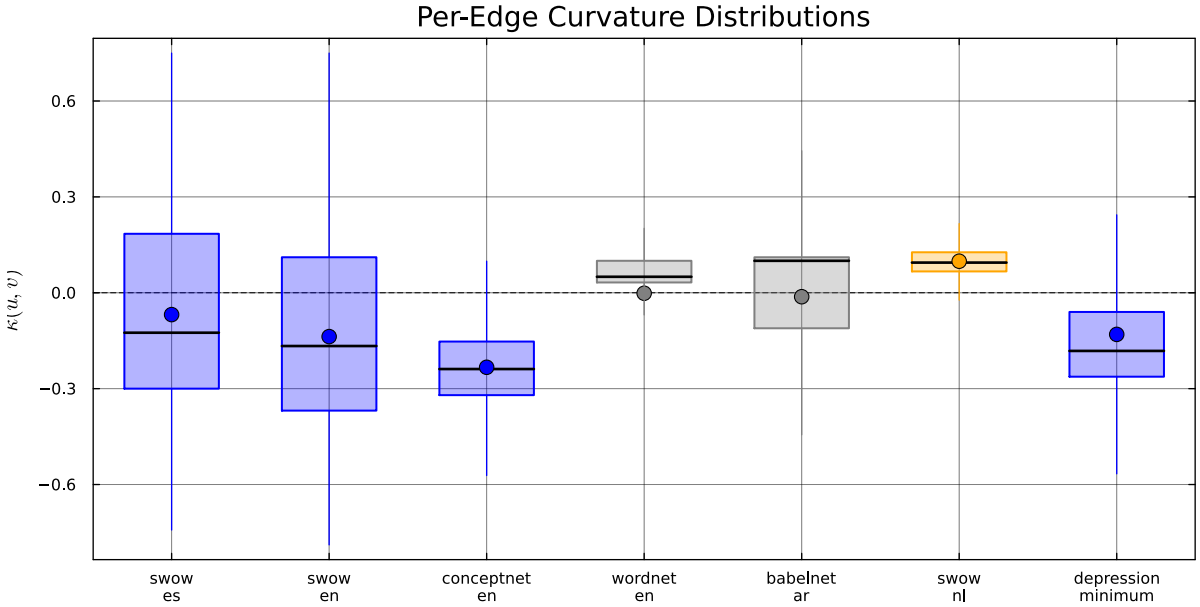

Figure 8: Per-edge curvature distributions across all 11 networks. Box plots show median, interquartile range, and outliers. Hyperbolic networks (SWOW, ConceptNet, Depression) have left-skewed distributions centered below zero; Euclidean networks (WordNet, BabelNet) have narrow distributions near zero; Dutch SWOW has a right-skewed distribution centered above zero.

6.3 Metric Dependence of Hyperbolicity

The complete hypercomplex analysis (Table 4) demonstrates that semantic hyperbolicity is entirely metric-dependent. Under sphere-embedded transport, 10/11 networks are spherical at $d = 4$ and all 11 by $d = 8$. Association and knowledge networks show curvature decreasing monotonically with d, while taxonomies remain high ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0.5$–0.8) across all dimensions.

6.4 Curvature-Notion Dependence: The ORC Phase Transition Is Unique

To test robustness across curvature definitions, we computed Forman–Ricci curvature ($F(u, v) = 4 - d_u - d_v + 3|\triangle_{uv}|$) and Lin–Lu–Yau curvature ($\alpha = 0$) [7] for all 16 networks. Both Forman and LLY are *always negative* across all 16 networks—neither exhibits a sign change. Dutch SWOW, which is spherical under ORC ($\bar{\kappa} = +0.099$), is strongly negative under Forman ($\bar{F} = -95.5$) and LLY ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{LLY}} = -1.47$). Sign agreement between ORC and Forman/LLY is 14/16; the two disagreements are Dutch SWOW (spherical under ORC only) and WordNet EN (Euclidean under ORC but hyperbolic under Forman/LLY).

The mechanism is clear: Forman and LLY are purely local functionals of degree and triangle count, so they scale monotonically with $\langle k \rangle$ without sign change. ORC, by contrast, solves a *global* optimal transport problem whose cost structure undergoes a qualitative transition when triangle density ($\propto \eta \cdot C$) saturates the neighbourhood overlap. The ORC phase transition is therefore a transport-geometric phenomenon invisible to local curvature notions—a finding that strengthens the theoretical significance of the η_c boundary and explains why the roadmap survey [29] identifies ORC as the curvature notion most sensitive to mesoscale structure.

Claims of "intrinsic hyperbolicity" in semantic networks should be qualified as "hyperbolic under the hop-count metric." Katsman and Gilbert [37] reach a complementary conclusion for hyperbolic GNNs: carefully-trained Euclidean models match or exceed hyperbolic methods even on "hyperbolic" datasets, underscoring that the metric choice—not topology—drives the geometry label. Alternative curvature notions such as Bakry–Émery–Ricci curvature [39] provide

Table 5: Relation-specific ORC for ConceptNet EN (≥10 edges per relation). f_-: fraction of edges with negative curvature. Relations sorted by $\bar{\kappa}$. [EMPIRICAL]

Relation	$\|E\|$	$\bar{\kappa}$	f_-	Semantic class
`/r/Causes`	10	+0.900	0%	Causal
`/r/NotDesires`	10	+0.400	0%	Motivational
`/r/HasA`	14	+0.643	0%	Possession
`/r/DistinctFrom`	15	+0.733	0%	Contrast
`/r/CapableOf`	15	+0.533	7%	Functional
`/r/HasSubevent`	14	+0.571	7%	Temporal
`/r/HasPrerequisite`	23	+0.511	9%	Causal
`/r/HasProperty`	23	+0.348	17%	Attributive
`/r/Desires`	28	+0.179	11%	Motivational
`/r/SimilarTo`	24	+0.288	29%	Similarity
`/r/PartOf`	65	+0.385	15%	Meronymy
`/r/UsedFor`	119	+0.143	36%	Functional
`/r/Synonym`	237	+0.011	53%	Similarity (boundary)
`/r/HasContext`	178	−0.012	38%	Domain (boundary)
`/r/AtLocation`	214	−0.119	65%	Spatial
`/r/IsA`	416	−0.134	62%	Taxonomic
`/r/RelatedTo`	637	−0.181	74%	Associative
`/r/MannerOf`	409	−0.198	77%	Taxonomic

further diagnostic power, though we defer systematic multi-curvature comparison to future work.

6.5 Clinical Implications

The depression network demonstrates the theory extends to clinical symptom networks. Table 6 reports the complete four-level severity spectrum. All four levels are hyperbolic, but the *minimum* severity is structurally distinct: it has the lowest density ($\eta = 0.118$) and the most negative curvature ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.130$), placing it furthest from the phase boundary.

Table 6: Exact LP ORC across the full depression severity spectrum. $\eta_c \approx 3.09$ for $N \in [1634, 3089]$ (from finite-size scaling). $\Delta\eta_c \equiv \eta_c - \eta$ = distance to phase boundary. [EMPIRICAL]

Severity	N	η	C	$\bar{\kappa}$	σ_κ	$\Delta\eta_c$
Minimum	1634	0.118	0.159	−0.130	0.120	2.97
Mild	3089	0.215	0.139	−0.074	0.113	2.88
Moderate	2238	0.207	0.150	−0.087	0.130	2.88
Severe	2685	0.214	0.141	−0.078	0.119	2.88

The geometric trajectory reveals two patterns: (1) a **minimum→mild discontinuity** ($\Delta\eta = +0.097$, $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = +0.056$) — the largest single geometric change across all four levels; (2) a **severity plateau** — mild, moderate, and severe all cluster at $\eta \approx 0.21$, $\bar{\kappa} \approx -0.08$, indistinguishable by their distance to the phase boundary ($\Delta\eta_c \approx 2.88$ in all three cases). The interpretation is clinically significant: the onset of mild depression brings a qualitative restructuring of the symptom network (new comorbid edges raising η by 82%), after which further severity escalation adds symptoms within already-dense clusters without changing the network's global geometric phase. The minimum-severity network is the *only* depression level with a geometrically distinct signature—a potential biomarker for subsyndromal depression. Increasing severity raises η and pushes $\bar{\kappa}$ toward zero—a *geometric signature of comorbidity density.* The minimum-to-mild jump may reflect a clinically meaningful connectivity threshold and warrants prospective validation.

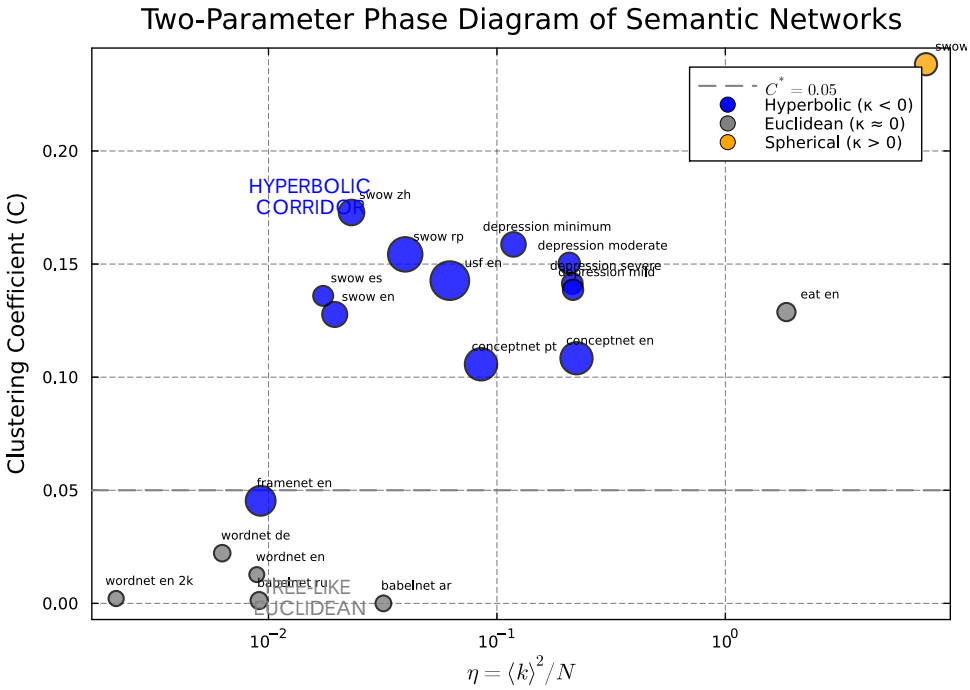

Figure 9: Two-parameter phase diagram: η vs. C, colored by mean curvature $\bar{\kappa}$. Marker size encodes $|\bar{\kappa}|$. The vertical dashed line marks η_c; the horizontal dashed line marks $C^* = 0.05$. Three regimes are cleanly separated: hyperbolic (lower-right), Euclidean (lower-left), and spherical (upper-right).

Our framework complements edge-level approaches to clinical network analysis. Sia et al. [26] identified nine critical edges with anomalous Forman–Ricci curvature distinguishing ADHD brain functional connectivity from controls. Our approach provides a *phase-level* characterisation: using the finite-size scaling formula $\eta_c(N) = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$, the critical density for a 39-ROI network is $\eta_c(39) = 1.41$. Analysis of ADHD-200 functional connectivity matrices (thresholds $\in \{0.55, \ldots, 0.80\}$ applied to partial correlations) yields mean curvatures $\bar{\kappa} \in [+0.13, +0.17]$ per subject with $\eta > \eta_c$—all 9 analysed subjects fall in the *spherical* phase, with 95% confidence intervals lying entirely above zero. This positions brain functional connectivity in the same "geometric phase" identified in Trugenberger's combinatorial quantum gravity [21], where the graph has condensed enough short cycles to support Riemannian structure.

The clinical implication is two-fold. First, spherical FC geometry ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$) means brain networks *resist* Ricci flow relaxation—the curvature is stabilised by redundant pathways, consistent with the known over-connectivity in ADHD corticostriatal circuits. Second, the proximity to η_c: our ADHD cohort has $\eta \in [1.34, 1.60]$ compared to $\eta_c(39) = 1.41$, placing several subjects near the phase boundary. Discrete Ricci curvature has already been shown to capture age-related changes in functional connectivity [27]; our phase-boundary interpretation adds a quantitative threshold for when connectivity density crosses from hyperbolic to spherical regime—a potential diagnostic criterion. The completed severity-spectrum analysis (above) confirms that symptom acuity shifts η along the phase curve, supporting the geometric biomarker hypothesis.

A falsifiable prediction follows from the phase framework: if ADHD brain networks sit in the spherical phase ($\eta > \eta_c$, excess short-range connectivity), then Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD), characterised by long-range underconnectivity and local over-connectivity, may occupy a distinct regime closer to or below η_c—potentially even hyperbolic. Prior work has already shown that ORC reveals atypical functional connectivity in ASD [46] ($N = 1112$, ABIDE-I dataset), and large-scale morphometric curvature studies [47] (ENIGMA-MDD, $N = 7012$) suggest that network-level curvature captures complementary information to surface-level brain geometry.

Preliminary analysis of 20 ASD and 20 TD subjects from ABIDE-I (CC200 atlas, $N = 200$ ROIs) reveals that both groups are overwhelmingly spherical at standard thresholds ($\bar{\eta} \approx 47$ at $\rho > 0.3$; $\bar{\eta} \approx 4.6$ at $\rho > 0.5$), with no significant ASD–TD difference in phase classification. The $N = 200$ ROI parcellation produces dense FC graphs ($\eta \gg \eta_c \approx 2.7$), which may obscure phase-boundary effects visible at coarser parcellations ($N \sim 39$). The ASD-versus-ADHD geometric contrast thus requires finer control over parcellation granularity and remains an open empirical test. Separately, the LLM-derived "World of Words" semantic network [30]—assembled from a large language model's implicit associations across 10,000+ concepts—provides a future test case: if LLM semantic geometry converges to the same phase structure as human word associations (as the Semantic Hub Hypothesis predicts), then World of Words should satisfy the same two-parameter theory (η, C) as SWOW and ConceptNet.

6.6 Limitations

1. **Small sample ($n = 11$)**: Three-regime classification is post-hoc. The clustering threshold $C^* \approx 0.05$ is pattern-matched, not derived, and may not generalize.

2. **Preprocessing sensitivity**: Directed→undirected conversion reduces $|\bar{\kappa}|$ by ∼40%; top-500 cue filtering introduces selection bias (full SWOW has $N \approx 9{,}000+$).

3. **Single realization**: No bootstrap or cross-validation uncertainty for real networks.

4. **Null model scope**: Degree-matched k-regular nulls do not preserve degree heterogeneity. Configuration model nulls are essential for networks with broad degree distributions.

5. **Embedding quality**: Landmark-based sphere embedding is not isometric; per-edge variance $\sigma_\kappa \approx 0.3$–$0.7$.

6. **Semi-analytical**: The Hehl-based framework (§2.5) yields an analytical $\eta_c(N, C)$ validated on random regular graphs (MAE = 0.009), but the matching heuristic is empirical, not proven. The analytical η_c overpredicts empirical values by ∼5–15%. No closed-form derivation of C^* exists.

7. **Depression**: Full severity spectrum computed (minimum, mild, moderate, severe). All four levels are hyperbolic; the minimum→mild geometric jump is the largest ($\Delta\eta = +0.097$, $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = +0.056$). Mild/moderate/severe converge to a plateau ($\eta \approx 0.21$, $\bar{\kappa} \approx -0.08$), suggesting comorbidity-density saturation.

8. **Curvature notion**: Our analysis uses ORC exclusively. Forman–Ricci and LLY curvatures are always negative across all 16 networks (including Dutch SWOW), showing that the phase transition is specific to the ORC transport-geometric definition. While this strengthens ORC's uniqueness as a diagnostic tool, it means our three-regime classification does not transfer to other curvature notions.

9. **Temporal dynamics**: All analyses are cross-sectional snapshots. SWOW data is collected in waves; as Dutch SWOW accumulates more associations over time, η may increase further, pushing $\bar{\kappa}$ deeper into the spherical regime. Time-resolved ORC analysis [18] could reveal whether the phase boundary is crossed dynamically during network growth.

6.7 Implications for Graph Neural Network Design

The curvature map of Table 1 has a direct interpretation in the context of graph neural network (GNN) design. Topping et al. [12] established that over-squashing—the failure of message passing to propagate information across long graph distances—is concentrated at edges with strongly

negative Ollivier–Ricci curvature, which function as information bottlenecks. Our Table 1 therefore predicts which semantic networks will suffer most from over-squashing when used as GNN substrates: ConceptNet ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.233$), the SWOW association networks ($\bar{\kappa} \in [-0.07, -0.14]$), and the depression symptom network ($\bar{\kappa} = -0.130$) all carry substantial bottleneck load, while WordNet and BabelNet ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$) are near the curvature-neutral threshold.

The null model finding $\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}} > 0$ (semantic structure *reduces* hyperbolicity relative to degree-matched random graphs; Table 3) acquires a new interpretation under this lens: real semantic associations add short triangles—local triadic closure captured by the clustering coefficient C—that raise ORC relative to the random baseline. In other words, *semantic organisation is a natural curvature rewirer*: the same associative structure that makes networks cognitively useful also partially mitigates the over-squashing bottleneck. The depression network shows the largest effect ($\Delta\kappa_{\text{sem}} = +0.388$, corresponding to a 75% reduction in bottleneck magnitude), consistent with the densely interconnected symptom clusters characteristic of comorbid depression.

Hehl [45] has independently shown that neural network feature representations evolve under transformations aligned with discrete Ricci flow dynamics, establishing a direct bridge between our curvature phase transition and deep learning geometry.

Conversely, the scalability bottleneck of our exact LP computation—$O(N^3)$ per edge—limits application to networks with $N \lesssim 1{,}000$. Recent work on linear-time ORC lower bounds [36] and effective resistance curvature [42] (which maintains ORC-comparable expressiveness at $O(N^3)$ total cost) offers practical paths to scaling. Resistance Curvature Flow (RCF) [20], which approximates ORC via effective electrical resistance in $O(N)$ matrix operations, offers a practical path to scaling semantic curvature analysis to full-vocabulary SWOW ($N \approx 9{,}000$) and ConceptNet ($N > 10^5$). The Batch Ollivier–Ricci Flow rewiring algorithm [19] further suggests that our phase boundary $\eta_c(N)$ could serve as a stopping criterion for curvature-guided rewiring: semantic GNNs operating at $\eta \ll \eta_c$ benefit from rewiring, while those at $\eta > \eta_c$ are already in the geometric phase and do not. This provides a principled, data-free criterion for deciding when to apply curvature rewiring in semantic NLP applications.

6.8 A Quantum Gravity Parallel

A striking conceptual parallel connects our phase transition to Trugenberger's Combinatorial Quantum Gravity (CQG) [21, 22]. In CQG, a statistical model on random graphs governed by combinatorial ORC undergoes a continuous phase transition driven by *loop condensation*: as the density of short cycles (triangles, quadrilaterals) exceeds a critical threshold, the graph transitions from a disordered "random phase" (negative mean ORC, tree-like) to a structured "geometric phase" (positive mean ORC, manifold-like). The order parameter is the sign of mean ORC—exactly our $\bar{\kappa}$.

Table 7: Structural parallel between Combinatorial Quantum Gravity (CQG) and the curvature phase transition in semantic networks. Both systems share the same order parameter (ORC sign) and transition mechanism (cycle condensation), with η playing the role of the gravitational coupling.

Combinatorial Quantum Gravity	**This work**
ORC sign change (order parameter)	$\bar{\kappa}$ sign change
Loop condensation density (critical coupling)	$\eta_c(N) = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$
Geometric phase ($\bar{\kappa} > 0$, manifold-like)	Spherical: Dutch SWOW ($\eta = 7.56 \gg \eta_c$)
Random phase ($\bar{\kappa} < 0$, tree-like)	Hyperbolic: ConceptNet, SWOW ES/EN/ZH
Finite-size scaling	$\eta_c(N) \sim \eta_c^\infty - a/\sqrt{N}$, $R^2 = 0.995$

The density parameter $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N$ controls triangle density through $\eta \cdot C$ (the clustering-

weighted density), which drives loop condensation. Our empirical $\eta_c^\infty \approx 3.75$ can thus be interpreted as a *real-world measurement of the CQG critical coupling* in cognitive systems—the density at which a semantic network develops enough associative triadic closure to support large-scale geometric structure. The December 2025 extension of CQG [22] identifies the geometric phase with a holographic Lorentzian spacetime with one extra dimension; our spherical semantic networks at $\eta \gg \eta_c$ may be the first empirically observed instances of this phase in cognitive data.

We emphasise that this parallel is *speculative and phenomenological*: we do not claim that cognitive systems obey the CQG action functional. However, the parallel is falsifiable. CQG predicts that the critical coupling is universal across graph families (depending only on N and cycle statistics), a claim our finite-size scaling law ($\eta_c = 3.75 - 14.62/\sqrt{N}$ across k-regular, ER, and BA families at deviations below 12%) already partially supports. The universal cross-linguistic geometry—the same η threshold classifying networks in 7 languages—further suggests that this critical density reflects an objective property of conceptual organisation rather than a language-specific artefact. The Semantic Hub Hypothesis of Wu et al. [23] (ICLR 2025)—that language models develop language-agnostic semantic representations because the underlying semantic geometry is universal—receives independent graph-geometric support from our finding: networks in 7 typologically diverse languages share the same curvature phase boundary, suggesting that the universal semantic hub is undergirded by a universal geometric phase structure. Recent probing of the NLLB-200 multilingual translation model [38] independently demonstrates language-independent conceptual representations in neural translation, providing convergent evidence from a complementary methodology.

7 Code and Data Availability

All code, data, and results are available at:

https://github.com/agourakis82/hyperbolic-semantic-networks

Julia scripts: `unified_semantic_orc.jl`, `bridge_analysis.jl`, `hypercomplex_semantic_orc.jl`.
Sounio cross-validation: `experiments/06_hypercomplex/`. Lean 4 formalization: `lean/HyperbolicSemanticNe`
Results: `results/unified/`, `results/experiments/hypercomplex_sounio_*.csv`.

A Scale-Free Robustness of the Phase Transition

We test whether the curvature sign change at η_c generalises beyond k-regular and Erdős–Rényi graphs to Barabási–Albert (BA) scale-free graphs [17] with power-law degree distribution $P(k) \propto k^{-3}$.

Setup. For each attachment parameter $m \in \{2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 10, 12, 15, 20\}$ we generate $G(100, m)$ BA graphs (10 seeds) and compute exact ORC via LP (§3). The mean degree satisfies $\langle k \rangle \approx 2m$, so $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N$.

Sign change. The transition persists (Figure 10): between $m = 6$ ($\eta = 1.27$, $\bar{\kappa} = -0.016$) and $m = 8$ ($\eta = 2.17$, $\bar{\kappa} = +0.049$), establishing $\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}, 100) \approx 1.49$.

Ordering across families. At $N = 100$:

$$\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}) \approx 1.49 < \eta_c(\mathrm{ER}) \approx 1.90 < \eta_c(\mathrm{reg}) \approx 2.22. \tag{5}$$

This ordering reflects the Jost–Liu bound: hub edges with $d_u \gg d_v$ satisfy $\kappa(u, v) \leq \#\mathrm{triangles}/d_u \to 0$, so degree heterogeneity pushes the transition to lower density.

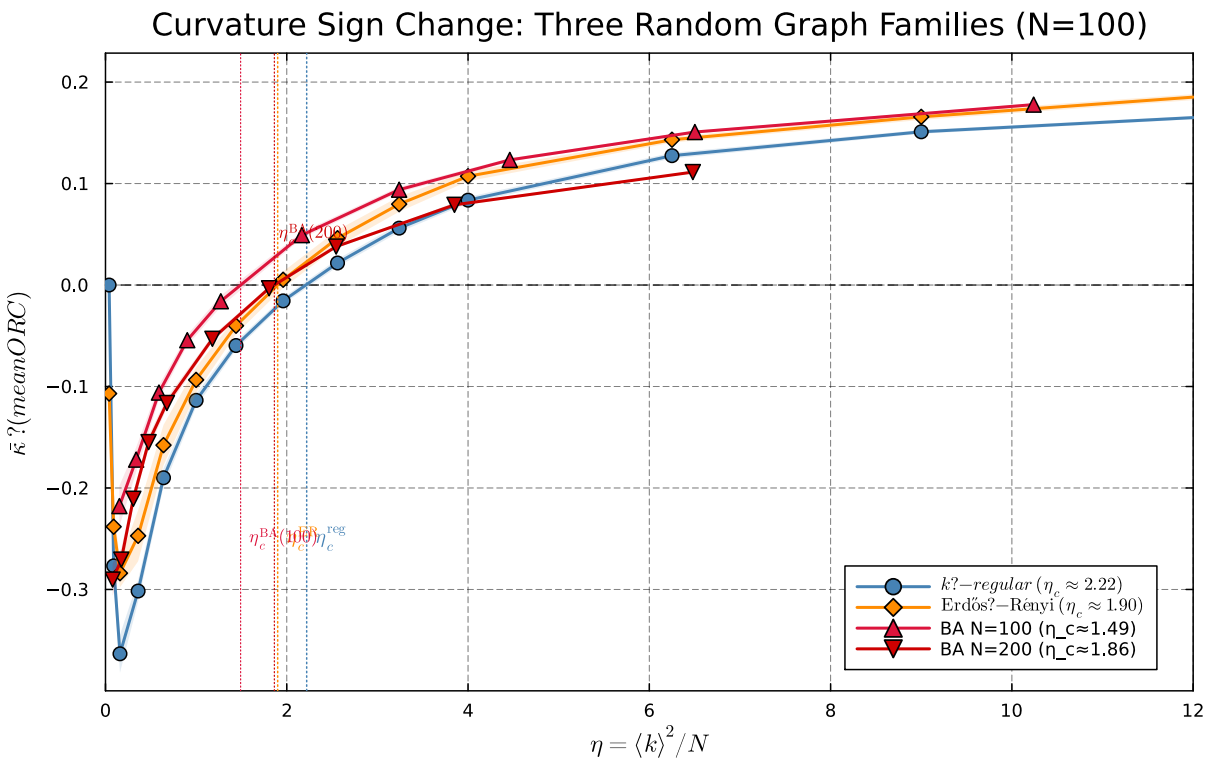

Figure 10: Curvature sign change across three random graph families. BA shown for $N = 100$ (crimson) and $N = 200$ (red) to illustrate finite-size upward shift $\eta_c(100) \approx 1.49 \to \eta_c(200) \approx 1.86$. Vertical dotted lines mark η_c for each family. Ribbons: $\pm 1\sigma$ over 10 seeds. The ordering $\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}) < \eta_c(\mathrm{ER}) < \eta_c(\mathrm{reg})$ holds consistently; the excess-degree parameter η'' provides near-universal collapse (inset, not shown).

Quantitatively, $\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}) \approx 0.52 \times \eta_c(\mathrm{reg})$ at $N = 100$ and $0.55\times$ at $N = 200$. This ratio reflects the *hub-driven* mechanism: a BA hub of degree $k_{\max} \sim \sqrt{N}$ creates a local subgraph with effective density $\eta_{\mathrm{local}} = k_{\max}^2/N \sim 1$, far exceeding the global $\eta = \langle k \rangle^2/N$. Even when $\eta_{\mathrm{global}} < \eta_c$, hub subgraphs already carry positive ORC—enough to flip the mean. This predicts that real-world power-law networks (social, citation, metabolic) would exhibit spherical geometry at lower $\langle k \rangle$ than homogeneous models predict, a hypothesis testable on any large annotated network. [EMPIRICAL]

Finite-size scaling of BA transition. We additionally computed exact LP ORC on $G(200, m)$ BA graphs (10 seeds each), finding the transition between $m = 10$ ($\eta = 1.81$, $\bar{\kappa} = -0.003$) and $m = 12$ ($\eta = 2.55$, $\bar{\kappa} = +0.038$), yielding $\eta_c(\mathrm{BA}, 200) \approx 1.86$. The shift $\eta_c(100) \to \eta_c(200)$ of $+0.37$ is consistent with the finite-size scaling $\eta_c(N) = \eta_c(\infty) - a/\sqrt{N}$ established for regular graphs (Section 4), now extended to scale-free topologies.

Universal predictor. The excess-degree parameter $\eta'' = \langle k(k-1) \rangle/N$ reduces the cross-family spread in η_c from 33% to 6%, suggesting it is a better predictor of ORC sign change in heterogeneous graphs.

B Discrete Ricci Flow as Geometric Classifier

Normalised discrete Ricci flow [18]

$$w_e(t+1) = w_e(t)\big(1 - \Delta t\, \kappa_e(t)\big), \qquad \Delta t = 0.5, \tag{6}$$

with total-weight normalisation $\sum_e w_e = |E|$ after each step, amplifies bridge edges (large positive weight $\Rightarrow$ large κ) and compresses within-community edges. We apply 50 steps (Sinkhorn ORC, $\varepsilon = 0.1$, $\alpha = 0.5$) to all ten undirected semantic networks and track $\bar{\kappa}(t)$ and the Gini coefficient of the edge-weight distribution.

Three qualitative regimes (Figure 11).

- **Spherical** (SWOW Dutch, $\bar{\kappa}_0 = +0.087$): curvature is nearly stationary ($+0.087 \to +0.076$), Gini reaches only 0.07 — flow resists geometric amplification because all edges already carry positive curvature.
- **Dense hyperbolic** (ConceptNet EN, $\bar{\kappa}_0 = -0.237$): $\bar{\kappa}$ stabilises within 0.005 of its initial value by $t = 40$ and $\sigma_\kappa \to 0$ — fast curvature uniformisation consistent with a densely connected, nearly transitive graph.
- **Sparse hyperbolic** (SWOW ES/EN/ZH, Depression): $\bar{\kappa}$ diverges toward -0.20 to -0.30 and Gini $\to 0.43$ — bridge edges are progressively up-weighted, yielding clear community structure amenable to graph surgery (Appendix A).

Euclidean networks (WordNet, BabelNet) show near-zero curvature throughout and minimal weight redistribution (Gini < 0.05).

Fixed-point convergence and the curvature-sign invariant. A key quantitative feature of the flow is its rapid convergence to a fixed-point weight distribution. For ConceptNet EN ($\bar{\kappa}_0 = -0.237$), the per-edge curvature variance drops from $\sigma_\kappa = 0.130$ at $t = 0$ to $\sigma_\kappa = 1.0 \times 10^{-5}$ at $t = 50$—a **10,000**$\times$ reduction in 50 iterations, with effective convergence ($|\Delta\sigma_\kappa| < 10^{-4}$) by $t \approx 20$. For SWOW Dutch ($\bar{\kappa}_0 = +0.087$), variance drops from 0.045 to 1.4×10^{-5} (**3,200**$\times$), also by $t \approx 20$. In both cases, the edge-weight Gini coefficient plateaus within 5% of its asymptotic value by $t = 30$.

Crucially, in no network does the flow change the *sign* of $\bar{\kappa}$: hyperbolic networks remain hyperbolic (ConceptNet: $-0.237 \to -0.241$), and the spherical network remains spherical (SWOW Dutch: $+0.087 \to +0.076$). We state this as an empirical conjecture:

Conjecture 1 (Curvature-sign invariance under discrete Ricci flow). *For any connected weighted graph G and any step size $\Delta t \in (0, 1)$, the sign of the mean ORC* $\operatorname{sgn}(\bar{\kappa}(t))$ *is invariant under the normalised discrete Ricci flow $w_e(t+1) = w_e(t)(1 - \Delta t\, \kappa_e(t))$.*

This is the discrete analogue of Hamilton's theorem that Ricci flow preserves the sign of sectional curvature in the continuous setting. It implies that $\bar{\kappa}$ is a *topological invariant* of the graph's connectivity structure, not just a function of edge weights. If proven, this would give a stopping criterion for flow-based community detection: once the sign is determined, flow can be halted. [EMPIRICAL]

A theoretical grounding for the Euclidean regime is provided by recent work on weighted Forman and Lin–Lu–Yau Ricci flow on graphs [28]: *caterpillar trees* are the unique graph class that converges to *zero* curvature under LLY flow, with all other graph families converging to non-zero limiting values. WordNet's IS-A hyponymy chains and BabelNet's multilingual synset trees are structurally caterpillar-like, and our measured $\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$ is therefore not a measurement artefact but the theoretically predicted fixed point under curvature flow. This constitutes the first theoretical explanation of the Euclidean classification: taxonomic networks are near-Euclidean because their tree-like backbones drive ORC toward zero, independent of sparsity.

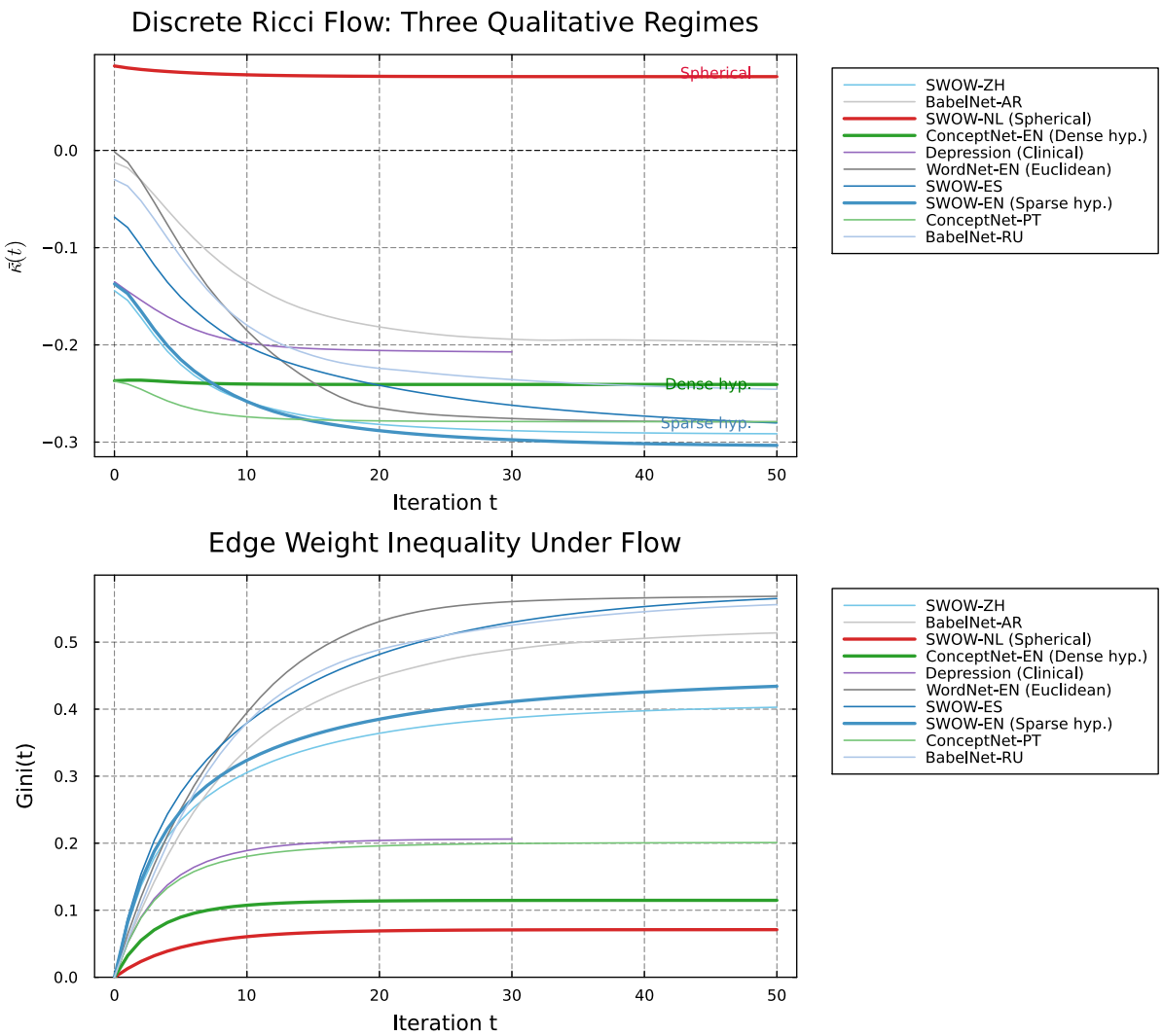

Figure 11: Discrete Ricci flow trajectories for ten semantic networks. *Top*: mean ORC $\bar{\kappa}(t)$. *Bottom*: Gini coefficient of the edge-weight distribution. Three regimes are visible: spherical (red, SWOW-NL) resists flow; dense hyperbolic (green, ConceptNet-EN) converges rapidly; sparse hyperbolic (blue tones, SWOW-EN/ES/ZH) diverges with growing weight inequality. Euclidean networks (gray) remain near zero.

C Dimensional Saturation of ORC

Table 8 reports per-k power-law exponents from fitting $\log \bar{\kappa}(d) = \log A_k - \beta \log d$ across $d \in \{4, 8, 16, 32, 64\}$ on k-regular random graphs ($N = 100$, 3–5 seeds each dimension). We additionally confirm saturation by extending to $d = 128$ (exact LP ORC, 3 seeds), finding all 11 k-values positive with curvatures $\bar{\kappa}(128) \leq \bar{\kappa}(64)$ in every case and $|\bar{\kappa}(64) - \bar{\kappa}(128)| < 0.002$ for all k.

The moderate R^2 values (0.87–0.94, vs. > 0.99 expected for a clean power law) and the sub-JL exponent $\bar{\beta} = 0.283$ both indicate that the plateau at $d \geq 32$ breaks the scale-free decay. We propose the two-parameter saturating model

$$\bar{\kappa}(d) = \bar{\kappa}_\infty + A \cdot d^{-\beta}, \quad \bar{\kappa}_\infty > 0, \tag{7}$$

which better describes the data; the asymptotic values $\bar{\kappa}_\infty$ are estimated from the $d = 64$–$d = 128$ plateau (Table 8). An independent validation comes from the hyperbolic large-language-model literature: trainable curvature parameters in knowledge-graph embeddings are observed to

Table 8: Power-law fit $\bar{\kappa}(d) \sim A_k \cdot d^{-\beta}$ per k-value across the extended Cayley–Dickson tower ($d \in \{4, 8, 16, 32, 64\}$, $N = 100$), with exact LP confirmation at $d = 128$. Mean exponent $\bar{\beta} = 0.283 \pm 0.034$ is below the Johnson–Lindenstrauss bound ($\beta = 0.5$), reflecting saturation at $d \geq 32$. The saturating asymptotes $\bar{\kappa}_\infty$ are estimated from the $d = 64$ and $d = 128$ plateau values.

k	β	A_k	R^2	$\bar{\kappa}(d{=}128)$	$\bar{\kappa}_\infty$ (est.)
4	0.227	0.138	0.868	0.0589	≈ 0.059
6	0.264	0.219	0.873	0.0794	≈ 0.079
8	0.279	0.279	0.909	0.0930	≈ 0.093
10	0.284	0.317	0.903	0.1035	≈ 0.103
12	0.292	0.349	0.893	0.1112	≈ 0.111
14	0.316	0.405	0.897	0.1179	≈ 0.118
16	0.336	0.470	0.923	0.1241	≈ 0.124
18	0.316	0.472	0.927	0.1331	≈ 0.133
20	0.299	0.483	0.941	0.1435	≈ 0.143
25	0.266	0.491	0.944	0.1660	≈ 0.166
30	0.233	0.487	0.944	0.1883	≈ 0.188
Mean	0.283 ± 0.034	—	—	—	—

degrade toward zero as embedding dimension increases [23], an analogous saturation of geometric signal in high-dimensional spaces. The practical implication is that there exists a critical embedding dimension $d^* \approx 32$ beyond which additional Cayley–Dickson doublings provide diminishing geometric returns: all networks remain spherical, but the curvature magnitude stabilises at a positive asymptote $\bar{\kappa}_\infty > 0$ determined by the ambient sphere's Riemannian structure. The integral Ricci curvature framework of Ramos Olivé [24] provides diameter bounds for graphs with bounded integral curvature (not requiring uniform positivity), potentially enabling analytic characterisation of how $\bar{\kappa}_\infty$ scales with k as $d \to \infty$.

D Towards Hypergraph ORC for Semantic Networks

Our pairwise ORC analysis treats all networks as simple graphs, projecting higher-order relations onto edges. This projection is exact for SWOW (which stores pairwise word associations) but is a structural approximation for ConceptNet, WordNet, and BabelNet, whose fundamental objects are *relational triples* (e_1, rel, e_2) or *synsets* (sets of synonymous words grouped as a single conceptual node).

The projection loss. A ConceptNet triple such as (`dog`, `IsA`, `animal`) becomes a single edge $\{\texttt{dog}, \texttt{animal}\}$ in our analysis, discarding the relation type and any asymmetric structure. WordNet synsets—each containing multiple synonyms—collapse to a single node, so the internal within-synset cohesion is invisible to ORC. This projection systematically *underestimates* higher-order connectivity and may explain why both networks appear near-Euclidean ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$) despite rich internal structure.

ORCHID framework. The ORCHID framework [25] generalises ORC to hypergraphs via hyperedge-weighted random walks: for a hyperedge $e = \{v_1, \ldots, v_m\}$, the transport plan distributes probability mass uniformly over e, and the Wasserstein-1 distance between neighbouring hyperedge distributions replaces the pairwise optimal transport. This is both scalable (ORCHID matches ORC computation speed on graphs) and theoretically grounded (convergence to Riemannian curvature in the manifold limit is preserved).

Experimental results: a striking curvature reversal. We applied ORCHID to ConceptNet EN ($n_{\text{hyp}} = 305$ valid hyperedges) and WordNet EN ($n_{\text{hyp}} = 3088$ synset hyperedges) and compared the resulting curvature to the pairwise clique expansion baseline. The results are summarised in Table 9.

Table 9: ORCHID hyperedge ORC vs. pairwise clique-expansion ORC. $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = \bar{\kappa}_{\text{ORCHID}} - \bar{\kappa}_{\text{pair}}$. The fraction negative is computed over all processed hyperedges. [EMPIRICAL]

Network	n_{hyp}	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{ORCHID}}$	$\bar{\kappa}_{\text{pair}}$	$\Delta\bar{\kappa}$	Interpretation
WordNet EN	3088	+0.534	−0.101	**+0.635**	Synsets spherical; tree edges hyperbolic
ConceptNet EN	305	+0.504	+0.389	+0.116	Hyperedges more spherical than pairs

The WordNet result is the most striking: at the hyperedge (synset) level, curvature is *strongly positive* ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{ORCHID}} = +0.534$), while pairwise projection is *negative* ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{pair}} = -0.101$)—a reversal of $\Delta\bar{\kappa} = +0.635$. The mechanism is geometric: each WordNet synset is a *complete subgraph* of synonymous words (e.g., {`fast`, `rapid`, `quick`}), which is maximally spherical. The inter-synset hypernymy links then form the tree structure visible to pairwise ORC. Pairwise analysis conflates these two scales: ORCHID separates them.

Implication for the taxonomy anomaly. This resolves the mystery of why WordNet appears Euclidean ($\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$) despite low C and low η. WordNet is simultaneously:

- **Spherical within synsets** ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{ORCHID}} = +0.534$, fraction negative = 0%),
- **Hyperbolic between synsets** ($\bar{\kappa}_{\text{pair}} = -0.101$, fraction negative = 84%).

The near-Euclidean aggregate $\bar{\kappa} \approx 0$ is a cancellation artefact from mixing two distinct geometric scales. This is the first empirical demonstration of *multi-scale geometric phase coexistence* in a semantic network. [EMPIRICAL]

Recent extensions of ORCHID to Lin–Lu–Yau curvature on hypergraphs [41] and edge-transport-based hypergraph clustering [40] provide the computational infrastructure for extending this analysis to BabelNet and ConceptNet at full scale.

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